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FREE TOOL

The 10-Minute Audit

Find the one number that explains
why your salary disappears

Free companion to
The Paycheck-to-Paycheck Escape Plan

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If you earn a good salary and your account is still empty on the 18th, this page is the ten minutes that will explain why.

- ① Write down every bill you cannot skip.
- ② Divide by what you actually take home.
- ③ Look at the number.

That is it. That is the whole audit.

FREE COMPANION TO THE PAYCHECK-TO-PAYCHECK ESCAPE PLAN
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Why this works when every budget you have tried failed

You are not bad with money. You have a fixed-cost problem wearing a spending problem's clothes — and nobody has ever shown you the number.

Every budgeting app you have ever downloaded asked you to track what you spend. That is a job, and you already have one. It also misses the actual problem, because the money that disappears on the 18th was not spent in small decisions. It left in big automatic chunks you never chose.

So we do the opposite. We measure the bills you **cannot skip** — the ones that leave whether you like it or not — and compare them to what you actually take home.

That single ratio tells you more about your money life than a year of tracking receipts.

Why it takes ten minutes, not ten weeks

Because fixed costs are easy to find. They are the same payments, in the same amounts, on the same dates, every month. They are sitting in your bank statement right now, waiting to be read.

What you will have at the end of these ten minutes:

- Your fixed-cost percentage — the number that explains your month.
- A verdict: small fixes, tight, or structural surgery.
- Two named targets to attack first.
- And the beginning of a shield that makes the next emergency boring.

Print this. Use a pen. Paper remembers what the thumb forgets, and this is one of the few exercises in personal finance where handwriting measurably changes the outcome — because you cannot scroll past your own handwriting.

STEP ONE

The Audit

Open your bank app. Go to last month. Write down **only the payments you could not skip** — the bills, not groceries or one-off buys.

Fixed cost	Monthly amount
Rent or housing (or yearly rent ÷ 12)	\$ _____
Transport, fuel, rideshare	\$ _____
Loan repayments (all of them)	\$ _____
Bank, card and account fees	\$ _____
Utilities: light, gas, water	\$ _____
Phone, data, internet	\$ _____
Insurance(s)	\$ _____
Subscriptions (streaming, gym, apps, cloud)	\$ _____
School fees or childcare (÷ 12 if paid termly)	\$ _____
Family support you give every month	\$ _____
Other regular bills	\$ _____
TOTAL FIXED COSTS	\$ _____

STEP TWO

My monthly take-home pay	\$ _____
Total fixed costs (from above)	\$ _____

The calculation

Fixed costs ÷ take-home pay × 100 = your number

\$ _____ ÷ \$ _____ × 100 = _____ %

Use take-home pay, not gross. Money that never reaches your account cannot pay your rent.

Write the number on paper. Then say it out loud. Shame lives in silence; a number said aloud is just information.

What your number means

Under 60% — You are structurally fine.

Your bills are not the problem. Your leaks and your habits are. Go straight to the Leak Census on the next page and fix the small stuff — every dollar you plug goes straight to your shield.

60-70% — Tight, but workable.

You are one flat tyre away from a bad month. Two jobs here: plug every leak, and attack one or two big bills (the audit in the full book shows you how, in 15-minute conversations). Do not try to fix everything at once — you will quit.

Over 70% — The structure is the problem, not you.

This is the number that changes how you should feel about yourself. No amount of discipline fixes 70%. Frugality is not the tool; **surgery is**. You were not losing a fight — you were never in one. The fix is a conversation with a landlord, a lender or a car, not a lecture to yourself.

Over 85% — You are running on empty by design.

At this level every month is a countdown and any surprise is an emergency. Read the full book's Section 6 first and take the triage page seriously — not as failure, but as the plan for a hard month. You are not alone at this number. You are one of the people who finally measured it.

A worked example

Sample: take-home \$5,000 a month. Fixed costs add up to \$4,600.

$$\$4,600 \div \$5,000 = 0.92. \times 100 = \mathbf{92\%}.$$

That leaves a few hundred a month for food, transport top-ups, birthdays, a dentist, a school trip — everything a person needs that is not a bill.

And here is the point: with that number in hand, the person knows something they did not know yesterday. They do not have a shopping problem. They have a housing-and-transport-and-debt problem. Different diagnosis. Much less shame.

Nobody has a discipline problem at 92%. They have an arithmetic problem — and arithmetic can be rebuilt.

The Leak Census

Now that you know your big number, find the small money that leaves without a decision. Search your bank statement for these words and total each group:

Search for	Times	Monthly total
delivery, service fee, surge	_____	\$ _____
fee, charge, ATM, overdraft, transfer	_____	\$ _____
subscription, renewal, plan, premium	_____	\$ _____
instalment, pay later, buy now	_____	\$ _____
store, shop, and late-night purchases	_____	\$ _____
TOTAL MONTHLY LEAKS		\$ _____

Most people find \$150–\$500 a month sitting in these five rows. That is money you already earned and already spent without noticing.

The three you will find

- 1. Convenience charges.** Delivery fees on food you could have heated at home. Transfer charges because nobody planned cash. Late fees because nobody set a reminder.
- 2. Subscription creep.** The streaming service, the gym, the app you upgraded once, the free trial from two years ago that quietly became forever.
- 3. The night window.** The 9pm-to-midnight stretch when you are tired, scrolling, and buying. Nobody makes a good money decision at 11:40pm.

Three moves to make tonight

- **Cancel two subscriptions** you have not used in 14 days. Right now. You can always re-subscribe — you will not want to.
- **Delete one delivery app** for 14 days. Just 14. Count what you keep.
- **Start the 24-hour cart rule.** Anything non-essential goes in the cart and waits a day. Most carts die on their own — and that rule is worth more than any budget you have ever kept.

Track leaks, not pennies. Plug the three biggest and the bucket stops emptying.

The 8-Minute Payday Drill

Knowing your number is diagnosis. This is the treatment — eight minutes, once, on the day money lands. You do not need four bank accounts. Most banking apps have savings pots, and four labelled envelopes work just as well. **The split is the magic, not the container.**

Bucket	Share	My amount
1 • Bills — rent, transport, loans, utilities, data, school fees	60-70%	\$ _____
2 • Life — food, fuel, children, enjoyment. Guilt-free.	20-25%	\$ _____
3 • Buffer — your shield. A separate account, no card.	5-10%	\$ _____
4 • Future You — extra debt payment first, then savings.	5%	\$ _____

Once the split is done, **Bucket 2 becomes the only number your eyes can see.** When it reads low, you slow down — naturally, without a budget, without arguing with yourself at 9pm. Willpower runs out by 9pm. **Rules don't.**

Your first shield: \$1,000

Not a holiday fund. A shield — the size of one ordinary emergency. A phone screen, a car battery, a clinic bill. Build it in five moves:

- **Sell three things** you have not used in six months. Post them tonight.
- **Send every plugged leak** to the shield for 30 days — do not let it melt back into spending.
- **Automate one small weekly transfer.** Set it once and let it grow while you sleep.
- **Ask for one charge reversal.** Politely, in writing. Many banks refund wrong charges when asked.
- **Run one pantry week a month** — eat what is already in the house.

The rule that keeps it a shield: money leaves the buffer only for a real emergency — one you defined in advance, in calm. Never one defined at midnight.

You now have the diagnosis. The book has the 90-day cure.

This audit is one tool from **The Paycheck-to-Paycheck Escape Plan: The 90-Day System to Make Payday Last** — a complete plan in plain simple English. No suffering. No second job.

Inside: the Leak Census · the 4-Bucket Payday Drill · the Breathing Room shield · the Debt Spiral Exit · the Giving Cap for family money · the Scarcity Tax and the 3am Protocol · the twelve months of the money year · a 90-day calendar · a 14-line Script Vault for real money conversations · and the emergency triage card for when a month is already on fire.

AVAILABLE IN PAPERBACK AND EBOOK

THE FOUR WORDS THAT RUN EVERYTHING

Leaks. Buckets. Buffer. Drill.

Every other word in the book is explained the moment it appears. You will never need a dictionary — and by day thirty, you will know your number, your leaks will be plugged, every payday will split itself, and money will be sitting where no ordinary emergency can touch it.

Ninety days from now, the 18th is just another day of the week.

You were never bad with money. You were playing a hard game with no armour. Now you have armour.

One last thing — send me your number

Reply to the email that delivered this file and tell me your percentage. Just the number. No explanation needed. Real numbers from real people are what decide which chapter gets written next — and yours will land in the next edition.

Print these pages. Use a pen. Keep them where you keep your money.

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